A gentle introduction to NVivo

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Territorial Acknowledgement

I would like to take this opportunity to acknowledge the traditional territories of the people of the Treaty 7 region in Southern Alberta.

The City of Calgary is also home to Métis Nation of Alberta, Region 3.

Disclaimer

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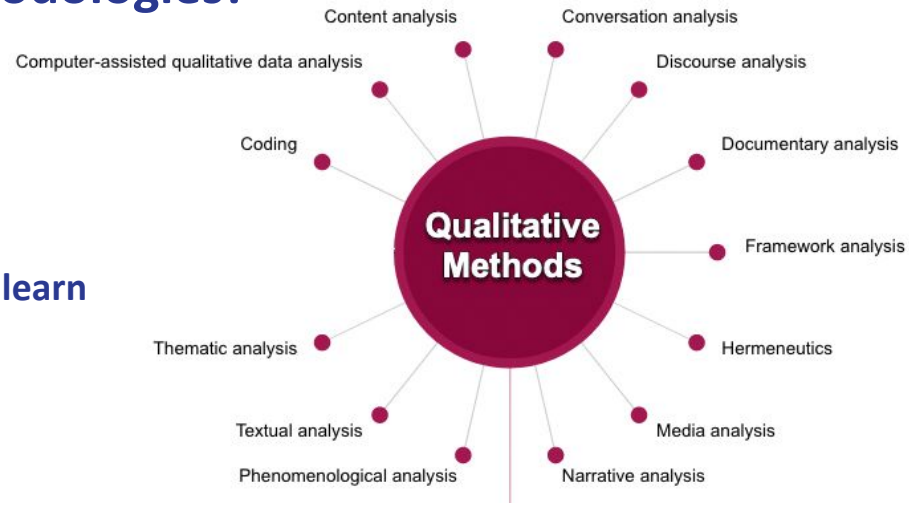
I am not an expert in research methodologies!



(Check out Sage Research Methods if you'd like to learn about a particular methodology…)

Qualitative Data

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"…the general term given to evidence that is **text based rather than numeric** in representation. These kinds of data result from interviews (group, individual, focus, and so on), observations (more typically unstructured but also structured), and documents (both formal, such as mission statements, as well as informal, such as letters) that may be analysed from a variety of perspectives."

Mathison, S. (2005). *Encyclopedia of evaluation* (Vols. 1-0). Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage Publications, Inc. doi: 10.4135/9781412950558

NVivo

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a computer-aided data-analysis tool for qualitative or mixed-methods research

- Works with multimedia and unstructured data
- We're looking at v15, the latest version
- We're only talking about the Windows version today, but it also runs on macOS
- Has been around (under an earlier name) since 1981! Since 1999 as NVivo
- Desktop, not web-based

NVivo pros and cons

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Pros

- The sample projects do a fantastic job of showing off all the capabilities
- Online documentation
- Handles most any document type you'll likely deal with
- Can work as part of a team (though it can be cumbersome)
- Multi-lingual (interface and/or analysis)

Cons

- It's 2025 and we still have different file types for macOS and Windows
- Was built by social scientists, not computer scientists
- Feature split between Windows/macOS
- Add-ons required for several features
  - Transcription
  - AI
  - Collaboration Cloud

NVivo in the future

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Big plans!

- Complete program rewrite, which will harmonize features between macOS and Windows
- Continued work on REFI-QDA implementation (https://www.qdasoftware.org/)
- Mobile coding?

There are many other tools for CAQDA…

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Comparison of CAQDAS

Application	Type	Source	Last Release	OS Supported	Tools
Quantitative Discourse Analysis Package package)	Client	Open	2019-01-02[9]	Windows, macOS, Linux	Word extracting, statistical analysis, visualization
QualCoder	Client	Open	2023-01-19[8]	Windows, macOS, Linux	Coding, Query, Visualization, Analysis
Aquad	Client	Open	2017-02	Windows	Coding, Sequence Analysis, Exploratory Data Analysis
Cassandre	Web-based/server	Open	2018-10-09	All (java-based)	Coding
CLAN	Client	Open	2019-06-10	Windows, macOS, Linux	Coding
Coding Analysis Toolkit (CAT)	Web-based	Open	2014-06-28[4]	All (web browser)	Coding
ELAN	Client	Open	2018-12-12[5]	Windows, macOS, Linux	Coding
Compendium	Client	Open	2014-02	All (java-based)	Coding
KH Coder	Client	Open	2015-12-29[6]	Windows, macOS, Linux	
RQDA (R package)	Client	Open	2018-03[12]	Windows, macOS, Linux	Coding, Aggregation, Query, Visualisation
ATLAS.ti	Client	Closed	2022-07[3]	Windows, macOS, iOS, Android, Cloud (web-based)	Coding, Aggregation, Query, Visualisation
Dovetail	Web-based	Closed	2021-08	All (web browser)	Coding, Query, Visualisation
Dedoose	Web-based	Closed	2016-12	All (web browser)	Coding, Query, Visualisation, Statistical Tools
MAXQDA	Client	Closed	2019-02-05	Windows, macOS	Coding, Aggregation, Query, Visualisation, Statistical Tools
NVivo	Client	Closed	2023-04[7]	Windows, macOS	Coding, Aggregation, Query, Visualisation
QDA Miner	Client	Closed	2016-11	Windows	
QDA Miner Lite	Client	Closed	2017-01-12	Windows	Coding
Qiqqa	Client	Closed	2016-09	Windows, Android	
Quirkos	Client / Web-based	Closed	2023-01[10]	Windows, macOS, Linux,[11] All (web browser)	Coding, Query, Visualisation
XSight	Client	Closed	2006 (abandoned)	Windows	
Transana	Client	Closed	2017-11[14]	Windows, macOS	Coding

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Computer-assisted_qualitative_data_analysis_software

Showtime!

Steps

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Decide which data you want to analyze - bringing in ALL content will just make things difficult to work with.

Clean your data before importing - you won’t be able to edit survey data after the fact.

Double-check that NVivo has correctly categorized your columns (open-ended vs descriptive)

Next steps

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Online (within program) help is actually pretty good!

My NVivo LibGuide: http://library.ucalgary.ca/guides/nvivo
(includes links to upcoming workshops)

Check out:
Using NVivo: An Unofficial and Unauthorized Primer (http://bit.ly/nvivo-primer)
(this is a slow-loading site)

References

Riddle, D., & Bickmore, S. (2021). *Responses to the Young Adult Literature Questionnaire of English Teachers (7-12) who Identify as Members of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-Day Saints* (Version 1). figshare. https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.16900075.v1